

StayBoost

Setup Guide - Go Live (No Code)

This guide takes you from nothing deployed to a live, working StayBoost you can open in your browser. It is written for someone who has never deployed software before. You only click buttons and copy-paste values - there is no code to write.

Simplest path (chosen): No custom domain yet. The public website and the AI Property Analyzer work fully. Login + the private dashboard need a custom domain - there is a short optional section at the end for when you are ready.

What you will create (all free to start):

Tool	What it is	Why
GitHub	Where the code already lives	Railway & Vercel deploy from it
Railway	Runs the database + back-end	The engine room
Vercel	Runs the website	What visitors see
Resend	Sends emails	Required for the API to start
Anthropic	Provides the AI	Powers the Analyzer

Total time: about 45-60 minutes. Take it one numbered step at a time.

Before you start - create 5 free accounts

Open each link, sign up (use 'Continue with GitHub' where offered - it's fastest), then come back. You don't need to do anything inside them yet.

1. GitHub - <https://github.com> (you likely already have this)
2. Railway - <https://railway.app> -> Login -> Login with GitHub
3. Vercel - <https://vercel.com> -> Sign Up -> Continue with GitHub
4. Resend - <https://resend.com> -> Sign Up
5. Anthropic Console - <https://console.anthropic.com> -> Sign Up

Tip: Keep a blank notes file open. Throughout this guide you collect a handful of values (web addresses and secret keys). I'll tell you exactly when to write one down and when to paste it back.

Part A - Get your secret keys (5 min)

Step 1. Anthropic API key

1. Go to <https://console.anthropic.com>
2. Left menu -> API Keys -> Create Key. Name it 'stayboost' -> Create.
3. Copy the key (starts with sk-ant-). Save it as ANTHROPIC_API_KEY.

! This key is shown only once. If you lose it, create another. The Analyzer needs a little paid credit - add about \$5 under Billing.

Step 2. Resend email key

1. Go to <https://resend.com> and log in.
2. Left menu -> API Keys -> Create API Key. Name 'stayboost', Full access -> Add.
3. Copy the key (starts with re_). Save it as RESEND_API_KEY.

Tip: You don't need to verify a domain for this guide. New Resend accounts can send test emails right away, which is enough to get StayBoost running.

Step 3. Make two random passwords

1. Open <https://www.uuidgenerator.net> and copy the long code. Save as JWT_SECRET.
2. Invent a second phrase, 20+ characters (e.g. stayboost-ai-link-9281). Save as AI_SERVICE_TOKEN.

[done] After Part A your notes have: ANTHROPIC_API_KEY, RESEND_API_KEY, JWT_SECRET, AI_SERVICE_TOKEN.

Part B - Database on Railway (10 min)

Step 4. Create the project

1. Go to <https://railway.app> and log in.
2. Click New Project.
3. Choose Deploy PostgreSQL (or Provision PostgreSQL).
4. Wait ~30 seconds. You now have a project with a database box.

Step 5. Make the database AI-ready (pgvector)

StayBoost needs a database that supports AI search ('pgvector'). Easiest way:

1. Delete the plain Postgres box: click it -> Settings -> Delete Service.
2. Click + New -> Database -> choose 'PostgreSQL + pgvector', or search the Template marketplace for 'pgvector' and deploy that one.

Tip: If you can't find pgvector on Railway, use Neon instead - it includes pgvector and has a free tier. Go to <https://neon.tech> -> Create project -> copy the Connection string -> save as DATABASE_URL -> skip to Step 7.

Step 6. Copy the database address

1. Click your Postgres box -> Variables (or Connect) tab.
2. Find DATABASE_URL (long line starting postgresql://). Copy it. Save as DATABASE_URL.

Step 7. Add Redis

1. On the project canvas click + New -> Database -> Redis.
2. When ready, click it -> Variables -> copy REDIS_URL (starts redis://). Save as REDIS_URL.

[done] Notes now also have: DATABASE_URL, REDIS_URL.

Part C - Deploy the AI service (10 min)

We deploy the AI brain first, because the main API needs its address.

Step 8. Add the AI service from GitHub

1. In the same project click + New -> GitHub Repo.
2. If asked, Configure GitHub App and give Railway access to your stayboost- repo, then return.
3. Pick the stayboost- repository. A new service box appears and starts building - that's fine.

Step 9. Tell it this is the AI service

1. Click the new service -> Settings.
2. Set Railway Config File to: services/ai/railway.json
3. Leave Root Directory empty (the repository root).
4. Open Variables and add the three below.

NAME	Value to paste
ANTHROPIC_API_KEY	your sk-ant-... key
AI_SERVICE_TOKEN	your random link password
AI_MODEL	claude-opus-4-8

1. Click Deploy (top right) and wait until it goes green / Active.

Step 10. Get the AI service address

1. AI service -> Settings -> Networking -> Generate Domain.
2. A public address appears, like stayboost-ai-production.up.railway.app.
3. Save it as AI_SERVICE_URL with https:// in front.

[done] Notes now have: AI_SERVICE_URL.

Part D - Deploy the main API (10 min)

Step 11. Add the API service

1. In the SAME project click + New -> GitHub Repo -> pick stayboost- again. A second box appears.

Step 12. Configure the API

1. Click it -> Settings -> set Railway Config File to: services/api/railway.json (Root Directory empty).
2. Open Variables and add all of these:

NAME	Value to paste
DATABASE_URL	your postgresql://... value
REDIS_URL	your redis://... value
RESEND_API_KEY	your re_... key
JWT_SECRET	your random UUID
AI_SERVICE_TOKEN	SAME link password as the AI service
AI_SERVICE_URL	your https://...railway.app AI address
AUTH_COOKIE_SECURE	true
NODE_ENV	production

1. Click Deploy and wait for green / Active.

Step 13. Get the API address

1. API service -> Settings -> Networking -> Generate Domain.
2. Save the address as NEXT_PUBLIC_API_URL with https:// in front.

Tip: Database tables are created automatically the first time the API starts. If the API box is red, open its Deploy Logs and read the last red line - it usually names the one variable that is missing or mistyped. Fix it and Redeploy.

[done] Notes now have: NEXT_PUBLIC_API_URL.

Part E - Deploy the website on Vercel (10 min)

Step 14. Import the project

1. Go to https://vercel.com and log in.
2. Add New... -> Project.
3. Find stayboost- and click Import.

Step 15. Point Vercel at the web app

1. Under Root Directory click Edit and choose apps/web.
2. Vercel auto-detects Next.js - leave build settings as they are.

Step 16. Add the website's variables

Open Environment Variables and add:

NAME	Value to paste
NEXT_PUBLIC_API_URL	your https://... API address
APP_URL	leave blank for now - filled in Step 18

Step 17. Deploy

1. Click Deploy. Wait 2-3 minutes.
2. Vercel shows your live address, like <https://stayboost.vercel.app>. Open it - you should see the StayBoost landing page.

Part F - Connect the two halves (5 min)

The website and the API must each know the other's address. Two quick fixes:

Step 18. Tell the website its own address

1. Vercel -> project -> Settings -> Environment Variables.
2. Set APP_URL to your live Vercel address (from Step 17). Save.

Step 19. Tell the API to trust the website

1. Railway -> API service -> Variables.
2. Add WEB_ORIGIN = your Vercel address (e.g. <https://stayboost.vercel.app>).
3. The API redeploys automatically. Wait for green.

Step 20. Redeploy the website once

1. Vercel -> Deployments -> ... menu on the latest -> Redeploy (so it picks up APP_URL).

Part G - Test it (5 min)

1. Open your Vercel address -> the landing page loads.
2. Try the AI Property Analyzer on the home page. Enter a sample listing and submit. After a few seconds you should get a report, not an error.

If the Analyzer shows "We couldn't generate your report right now", check in this order:

- NEXT_PUBLIC_API_URL on Vercel doesn't exactly match the API's Railway address (no trailing slash, includes https://).
- AI_SERVICE_URL or AI_SERVICE_TOKEN differ between the two Railway services - they must match.
- The Anthropic account has no credit - add about \$5 in the Console.

After any change, redeploy the service you changed and test again.

That's a live StayBoost. The public site and AI Analyzer are working.

Optional - Turn on Login & Dashboard later

Login and the private dashboard need the website and API to share one parent domain (browsers block the login cookie across two unrelated .vercel.app / .railway.app names). You don't need this to demo StayBoost, but when ready:

1. Buy a domain (namecheap.com or porkbun.com) - about \$10/year. Say you buy mystayboost.com.
2. In Vercel: Settings -> Domains -> add app.mystayboost.com. Copy the DNS record it shows.
3. In Railway: API -> Settings -> Networking -> Custom Domain -> add api.mystayboost.com. Copy its DNS record.
4. At your registrar: open DNS settings and paste in both records. Wait ~15 minutes.

5. Update variables and redeploy each: Vercel APP_URL and NEXT_PUBLIC_API_URL to the new addresses; Railway API WEB_ORIGIN and APP_URL to https://app.mystayboost.com; add Railway API AUTH_COOKIE_DOMAIN = .mystayboost.com
6. Now Sign up / Log in works, and the dashboard (channels, reservations, sync) is reachable.

Your values cheat-sheet

Keep these somewhere safe (a password manager is ideal). Never share or commit them.

Name	Where you got it	Used in
ANTHROPIC_API_KEY	Anthropic Console	Railway -> AI
RESEND_API_KEY	Resend	Railway -> API
JWT_SECRET	uuidgenerator.net	Railway -> API
AI_SERVICE_TOKEN	you invented it	Railway -> AI and API (same value)
DATABASE_URL	Railway/Neon Postgres	Railway -> API
REDIS_URL	Railway Redis	Railway -> API
AI_SERVICE_URL	Railway -> AI -> Networking	Railway -> API
NEXT_PUBLIC_API_URL	Railway -> API -> Networking	Vercel + Railway API
WEB_ORIGIN / APP_URL	Vercel -> your site address	Railway API + Vercel

Quick troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
A Railway box is red	A variable missing/mistyped	Open Deploy Logs, read the last red line, fix that variable, Redeploy
Site loads but Analyzer errors	API URL wrong or AI token mismatch	Re-check Steps 13, 16, 9; redeploy
'CORS' / blocked in browser	WEB_ORIGIN != Vercel address	Fix Step 19, wait for redeploy
Build fails on Vercel	Root Directory not apps/web	Step 15
Can't log in	Expected without a custom domain	See the Optional section

Stuck on a specific red error line? Copy that exact line and ask - it almost always points to one missing value.